that this is just a modern façade, a false front to a much older building, built in the traditional Keralan regional style found all the way down the Malabar coast from about the sixteenth century onwards.

The local imam welcomes us with a cheery greeting and handshake. He seems genuinely pleased to see non-Muslims such as ourselves and takes great pride in showing us around his mosque and its little museum. And he has every right to be proud, because this modest little building has a claim to be the oldest mosque in India. Its earlier predecessor may even have been raised during the lifetime of the Prophet, making it one of Islam's earliest mosques outside Arabia.

The Cheraman Juma Masjid takes its name from the local Chera kings, who became known collectively as the Cheraman Perumal, or 'great ones of the Cheras', one of whom who is said to have been so impressed with an early Muslim seafarer to his shores and his new religion that he quit his kingdom and sailed to Arabia, where he met and talked with the Prophet himself in Medina. He died on his way back and was buried in Salalah in present-day Oman, but before his death he asked a companion of the Prophet, Malik Bin Dinar, to spread the message of Islam in his homeland. Malik Bin Dinar then travelled through Kerala seeking permission from local Hindu rulers to set up a number of mosques before returning home, the first of these being the Cheraman Juma Masjid.

Arabs from what is now Oman and Yemen had been involved in the Indian spice trade for centuries as masters of the Indian Ocean, their navigators taking full advantage of the seasonal winds they called *mausim* (literally 'season', from which the English word 'monsoon' is derived by way of the Portuguese *mauçam*). In early summer, as the Indian interior began to heat up and draw in moisture-laden air from the Arabian Sea, they pointed their dhows towards the Malabar and Konkani coasts and let the wind fill their sails.